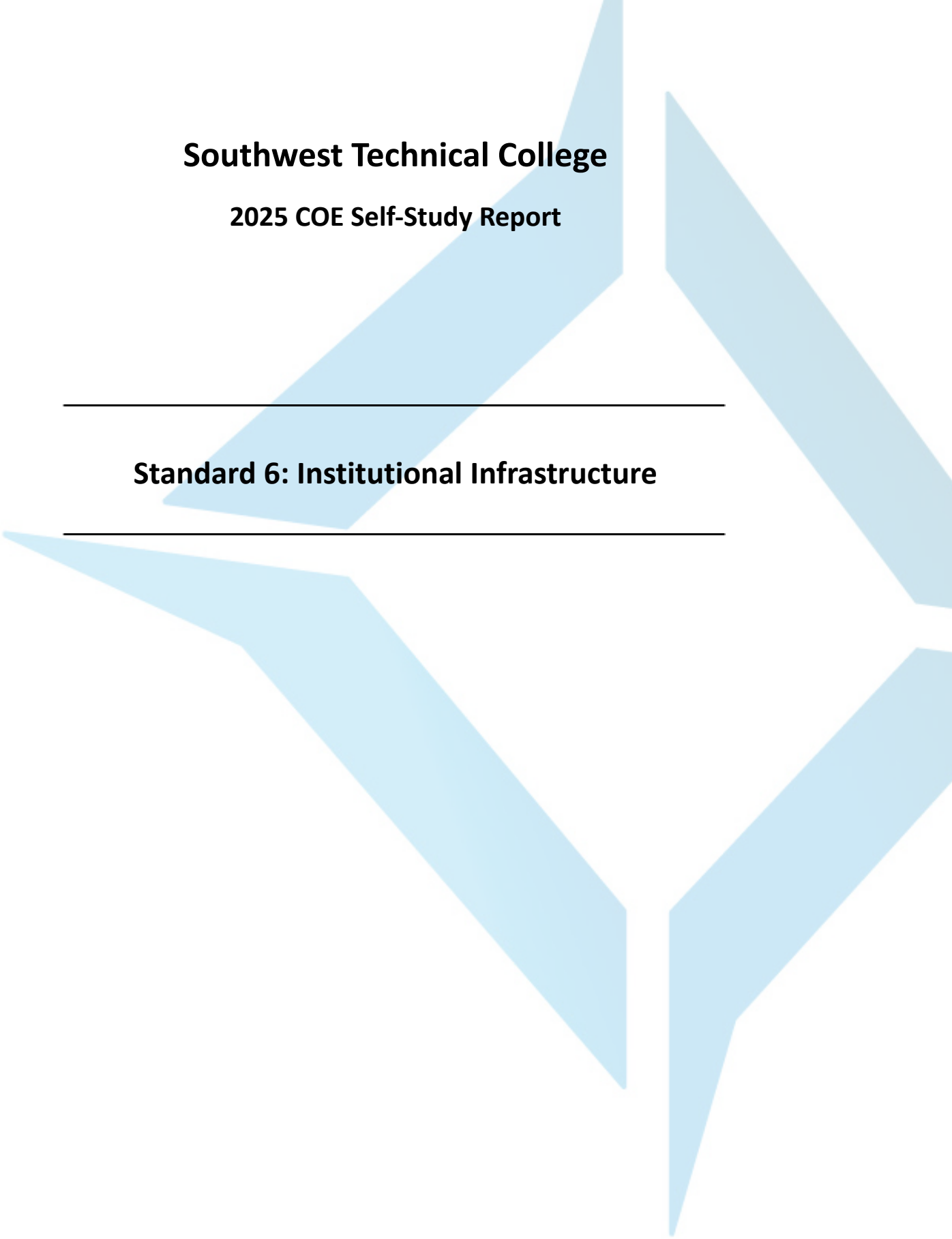




Southwest Technical College

2025 COE Self-Study Report

Standard 6: Institutional Infrastructure

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Introduction

Physical facilities at the Southwest Technical College include the Main Campus and additional instructional service centers, which are utilized in accordance with memoranda of understanding agreements. The College facilities are cleaned, maintained, and managed to support the needs of students and the mission of the institution. The Director of Facilities and the Director of Information Technology (IT) oversee safety and security, regulatory compliance, and general maintenance for all physical resources at the College. Information Technology provides support for all technical systems maintenance, repairs, and improvements.

Analysis

A. Physical Resources

- 1. A plan for the ongoing operation and maintenance of physical facilities has been developed and is in use.**

The Facilities Operations & Maintenance Plan and Technical Infrastructure Plan outline the overall scope, process, development, maintenance, and improvement of physical resources and technical infrastructure services at the College.

The operation and maintenance plan addresses the following elements:

- 2. Adequacy of and improvements to physical facilities.**

The Facilities Operations & Maintenance Plan addresses the ongoing operational and maintenance requirements of physical facilities. Improvements to physical facilities are addressed in the “Operations, Maintenance, and Upgrades” section of the plan.

- 3. Budget available for facility maintenance and improvement.**

The Facilities Department has an annual budget maintained by the Finance Department and is readily available.

- 4. Personnel.**

The Facilities Operations & Maintenance Plan outlines the duties and responsibilities of facilities and information technology personnel at the College.

- 5. Non-instructional equipment and supplies.**

The Facilities Operations & Maintenance Plan identifies the use, replacement, and disposal of instructional and non-instructional equipment and supplies.

6. Compliance with relevant state laws, federal codes and procedures.

All processes and procedures of the Facilities Operations & Maintenance Plan align with relevant state law and federal codes.

7. Annual evaluation of the plan (and revised as necessary).

The Facilities Operations & Maintenance Plan is managed by the Director of Facilities and is evaluated on an annual basis by the Physical Resource Committee and revised as needed. Changes to the plan are approved by the President's Cabinet, which consists of administration, faculty, and staff.

8. Physical facilities at all locations provide adequate, safe, and clean facilities with appropriate supporting utilities for classrooms, laboratories/shops, offices, restrooms, lounges, meeting rooms, parking, etc.

The physical facilities of the College are sufficient to meet ongoing demands for space and infrastructure. The main campus and all instructional service centers are regularly maintained, cleaned, and updated to provide students with a safe and clean learning environment. Classrooms, labs, shops, offices, restrooms, lounges, meeting rooms, parking, and all other facilities at the College are equipped with supporting utilities to promote student learning and ensure compliance with state and federal regulations relating to occupational safety.

The College uses a customer management system to track maintenance requests when improvements or repairs are required. The Facilities Department may request third-party assistance for maintenance items that are beyond their scope of ability or resources.

B. Health and Safety

1. A written plan for assuring the health and safety of the institution's employees, students, and guests to maintain readiness is in use and includes procedures for reporting and investigating incidents affecting the health and safety of the institution's constituents.

The College's Health and Safety Plan details the process for reporting and investigating accidents. Incident report forms are located on the Employee Hub via the College's website (www.stech.edu/hub). This report includes information about location, cause(s), injuries, and medical treatment provided. The form allows the Director of Facilities, Campus Safety Coordinator, Vice President of Student Services (student incidents), and Director of Human Resources (employee/visitor incidents) to review the accident and the associated response, and take corrective action as needed. Additionally, safety concerns can be reported via the College's website.

The health and safety plan

2. Has been distributed to employees.

The Health and Safety Plan is available to employees via the College's website.

3. Is evaluated annually with input from employees (and revised as necessary).

The plan is evaluated on an annual basis—and revised as necessary—by members of the Safety Committee, which consists of administrators, faculty, and staff.

4. Ensures basic information about the plan is available to students.

The Health and Safety Plan is available to students via the College's website.

5. First aid supplies are readily available.

First aid supplies are readily available throughout the College's campuses. The location of these supplies can be located on the College's life safety maps which are located on the Employee Hub via the College's website.

C. Technical Infrastructure

1. A plan for the institution's technical infrastructure has been developed and is in use.

2. Addresses adequacy, improvements and protection of the technical infrastructure, including distance education infrastructure if applicable.

Southwest Technical College's plan for its technical infrastructure is developed, maintained, and implemented by IT and administrative staff. The plan includes details about distance education infrastructure.

3. Addresses the ongoing operation and maintenance of technical infrastructure, including distance education infrastructure if applicable.

The Technical Infrastructure Plan addresses the operation and maintenance of technical infrastructure, including details about distance education infrastructure.

4. Ensures the privacy, safety, and security of data of institutional data.

The Technical Infrastructure Plan addresses the operation and maintenance of technical infrastructure, including details about distance education infrastructure.

5. Ensures computer system and network reliability whether provided directly by the institution or through contractual arrangements.

The Technical Infrastructure Plan addresses computer system and network reliability, including power and data backups. The plan details cloud services, network agreements, and filtering.

6. Is evaluated annually (and revised as necessary).

The IT Committee annually evaluates the Technical Infrastructure Plan and revises it as necessary. The annual evaluation is intended to ensure the plan's purpose is met and the associated resources and infrastructure are functioning as intended. Changes to the plan are approved by the President's Cabinet, which consists of administration, faculty, and staff.

7. Ensures basic information about the plan is available to the administration, faculty, and staff. [See Section VII. Definitions – Plan]

The Technical Infrastructure Plan is available on Southwest Technical College's website.

8. The technology used by the institution to deliver services and, if applicable, program content to students meets the needs of the students without creating barriers to student support or learning.

Instructional and non-instructional equipment and supplies are used in accordance with manufacturer recommendations and standard practices.

As part of the regular schedule, the Information Technology department performs preventative maintenance and upgrades to the physical resources and technical infrastructure. In the case of highly technical maintenance, repairs, replacement, or disposal of non-instructional equipment and supplies, the work may be contracted with a qualified company.

In the case of specific program equipment (i.e., instructional equipment), the program director or faculty are the experts. In some cases, maintenance or repairs can be performed internally, while other situations may require outsourcing to technical experts. Each program has an equipment budget that is controlled by the program director. During the budgeting process, the program can make requests for the replacement, disposal, and/or upgrade of equipment.

Each department and program budgets for and purchases the supplies that are necessary for its operations. The Director of Information Technology develops an annual budget for IT support function supplies.

9. Procedures for preserving and protecting student coursework, testing, and records are provided by measures that ensure their preservation and protection.

Utilizing the SCALE (H3C) virtual environment, all mission-critical servers operate as a virtual environment. A secondary backup array is in one of the college's secondary campus locations, where a snapshot is taken and stored every 15 minutes. In the event of a server or

array failure, critical servers can be brought online using either the primary array or directly on the secondary array. Having this capability reduces the amount of time critical services and data would be unavailable. As a further precaution, full backups are made on a removable drive each night (Monday through Friday). The removable drives can store 30 days of restorable copies. Backups are tested in a sandbox environment to ensure restorability.

Challenges and Solutions

Southwest Technical College's IT department faces a range of challenges, from maintaining an aging infrastructure to adapting to rapidly evolving technologies. Balancing security and accessibility is a constant concern, as we must protect sensitive data while ensuring seamless access for students, faculty, and staff across multiple devices and platforms. Budget constraints often limit our ability to invest in necessary upgrades or staff training, even as the demand for reliable technology grows. Additionally, the IT department must support diverse needs, such as hybrid learning environments, research computing, and campus-wide communication systems, all while addressing cybersecurity threats and meeting compliance requirements. These challenges require strategic planning, cross-department collaboration, and innovative problem-solving to meet the demands of a modern campus.

Summary

Southwest Technical College's program offerings for students are diverse, requiring a significant investment in equipment, technology, lab space, classrooms, testing centers, offices, and general gathering areas. Oversight of these areas is the primary responsibility of the Director of Facilities and Director of Information Technology. The Facilities and IT teams strive to maintain an adequate, safe, and clean environment essential for student learning.